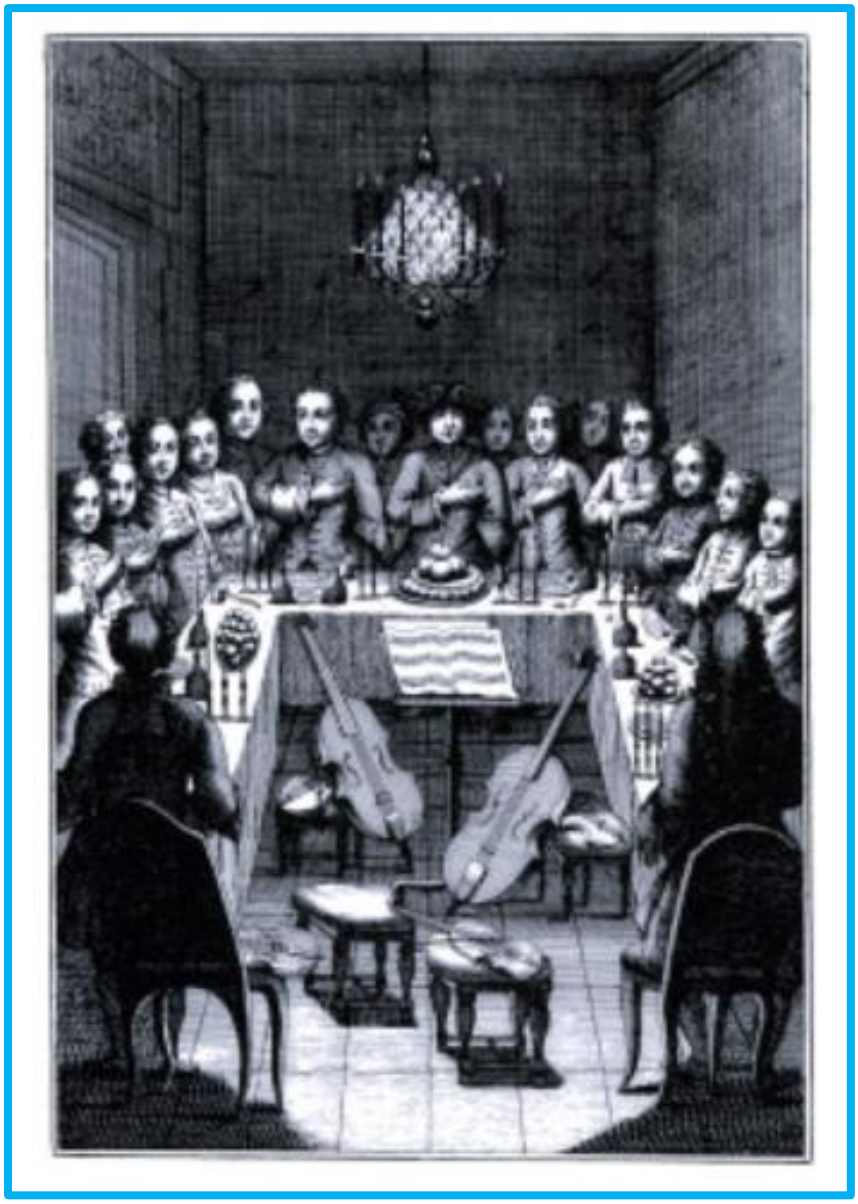
The Fleet House Light Blues Club presents

THE FESTIVE BOARD

Lodge of Instruction



Welcome from R.W. Bro Neil Connolly, Provincial Grand Master of the Province of Hertfordshire

A welcome message from the PGM & President of the Fleet House Light Blues Club

I am particularly pleased to have been asked to write an introduction to the Fleet House Light Blues Club Festive Board Instruction brochure.

We are invited to '*make a daily advancement in our masonic knowledge*' & for most of us this involves trying to learn & remember our ritual & regularly attend a Lodge of Instruction.

Our LOIs tend to focus purely on ritual & protocol within the Temple, but rarely do we consider the other half of our meetings, the Festive Board.

Amongst the many tenets of our Craft we are encouraged to promote '*the grand design of being happy & communicating happiness'* & where best to practice this than at our Festive Boards.

This is the part of our meetings where we are able to relax & enjoy each other's company within the convivial atmosphere of a good meal not to mention some drink too.

This event is designed to impart a better understanding of the protocols that should be observed during the more relaxed half of our meetings which, despite not being held in the Temple, does have a structure & formality that should be understood & observed.

The following is intended to provide some information to compliment an informal evening & can be supplemented with notes for later reflection or as a blueprint for an alternative Lodge of Instruction evening.

I am sure that you will find it both instructive & thought-provoking.



Neil

About the Fleet House Light Blues Club

The Fleet House Light Blues Club supports “Light Blue” Freemasons throughout Hertfordshire through its three pillars: Explore, Discover & Engage.

Through events, mentoring, & lodge visiting, the FHLBC helps newer Masons feel connected to the Province of Hertfordshire & more involved in the Masonic community.

EXPLORE

For many newer Masons, the Festive Board can feel unfamiliar at first. This evening provides the opportunity to:

- experience a Festive Board in a supportive setting,
- understand traditions & etiquette,
- & build confidence in Lodge visiting.

DISCOVER

It attempts to explain the rich history & tradition of the Festive Board & enable newer brethren to be confident in taking part:

- the meaning behind key customs,
- the Toasts,
- the Masonic Fire,
- & Festive Board etiquette.

ENGAGE

It also provides an opportunity to:

- meet fellow Light Blues,
- speak with experienced Masons,
- & ask questions

What Is the Festive Board?

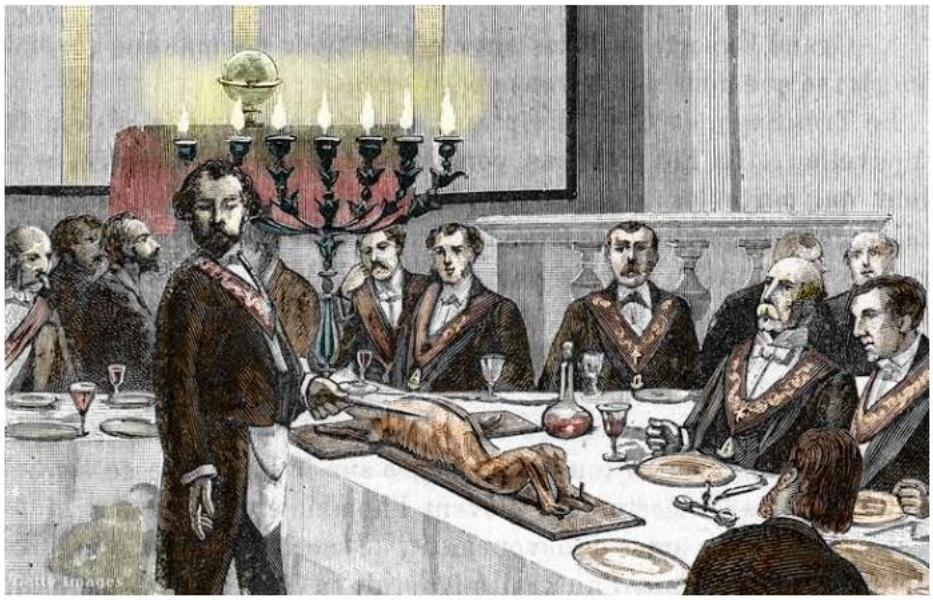
Historically, the Festive Board has existed for centuries & developed from the traditions of early stonemasons, who gathered after work for food & fellowship.

The Festive Board has been an important part of Freemasonry since the earliest lodge meetings of the 18th century, when brethren gathered not only for ceremony, but also for dining, conversation, music & toasts.

Early Freemasons held large “Grand Feasts” on the feast days of St John the Baptist & St John the Evangelist, & some lodges even held “Table Lodges”, where dining took place within the lodge room itself.

Food, drink & fellowship were considered central to Masonic life, helping strengthen friendships & unity within the fraternity. Following the union of the “Antients” & “Moderns” in 1813, the modern Festive Board developed into the dining tradition we have in lodges today.

Whilst more relaxed than the ceremony itself, it still follows long-standing traditions & etiquette which form an important part of Freemasonry.



A Festive Board "Lodge of Instruction"

Many newer Freemasons (and more experienced ones too!) quietly wonder:

- *"When should I stand?"*
- *"What is Masonic Fire?"*
- *"What do I say in a toast?"*
- *"Why are certain traditions followed*?"

With these & other questions, the aim of this LOI is to help all brethren understand:

- how a typical Festive Board works,
- the purpose behind the toasts & customs,
- what is expected during the evening,
- & how to take part with confidence

Is the Festive Board Formal?

Yes.... but relaxed!

The Festive Board is considered an extension of the lodge meeting itself. While there is conversation, laughter & enjoyment, there is also etiquette & structure.

Good manners, respect for others & attention to the Worshipful Master remain important throughout the evening.



A Typical Order of Events

The Festive Board typically includes:

- dining together,
- wine-taking
- formal toasts,
- speeches,
- & masonic fire!

Every lodge will have its own traditions & style, but a typical Festive Board often follows this structure:

1. Brethren take their seats
2. The Worshipful Master enters
3. Grace is given before the meal
4. Dinner is served
5. Wine-taking (usually between the first and second course)
6. The return of Grace
7. Formal Toasts
8. Responses to Toasts
9. Raffle (if held)
10. Tyler's Toast

The Key People

The Worshipful Master (WM)

The Worshipful Master leads the evening & controls the proceedings using the gavel.

When the WM gavels:

- conversation stops immediately,
- Brethren come to order,
- & attention is given respectfully.

The respect is not for the “noise” of the gavel itself, but for the office of Master.

The Director of Ceremonies (DC)

The DC manages the smooth running of the Festive Board:

- announcing toasts,
- guiding proceedings,
- maintaining etiquette,
- & helping ensure the evening flows properly.

The DC is the “conductor” of the evening.



The Lodge Stewards

The office of Steward is likely to be your first in the lodge. A steward’s main function is being responsible for serving drinks, conducting the raffle, etc. It is a very good way to meet the members & put names to faces!

The Tyler

The Tyler traditionally stands guard outside the door of the lodge, armed with a drawn sword.

Historically, the Tyler also had a more practical role in ensuring that the brethren, & particularly the Worshipful Master, after an enthusiastic Festive Board, returned home safely at the end of the evening!

The evening usually concludes with the famous “Tyler’s Toast”.

The Key Events

Grace

Before the meal begins, Grace is normally given by the Chaplain. Sometimes it is sung.

This is a traditional expression of thanks & reflection before dining.

Many lodges use ancient forms of Grace that have existed for hundreds of years.

Wine-Taking



Wine-taking is not the same as a formal toast. It is a mutual gesture of goodwill between the Worshipful Master & another brother or brethren & is usually done briefly between courses. Note that wine-taking is NOT fired (see below).

The wine taking is announced by the DC:

- the DC announces with whom the WM "*would be pleased to take wine…"*
- both WM & the individual(s) stand (unless otherwise instructed)
- glasses are raised & wine is taken,
- both parties sit

Wine-taking can be between the WM & an individual brother, or between the WM & several brethren. Often it is a way of acknowledging the assistance of various brethren in the ceremony:

"*The WM would like to take wine with all those brethren who assisted in the ceremony this evening.*"

The wine-taking is preceded by the WM standing & asking his wardens:

- "*Bro Wardens, how do you report the glasses in your respective columns*?"

The Wardens both stand & reply:

- The Junior Warden: "*Fully charged in the South, Worshipful Master*"
- The Senior Warden: "*Fully charged in the West, Worshipful Master*"

"*Charged*" here simply means that the brethren's glasses are filled with the appropriate wine (or water!) before taking wine.

The Junior & Senior Wardens are traditionally “situated” in the South & West of the lodge (as explained in the ceremony of Opening the Lodge in the First Degree), & thus they traditionally occupy these same positions in the dining room!

The form of the reply to the WM’s wine taking often depends on an individual lodge’s traditions.

Note that the wine-takings are preceded by a single knock of the WM (occasionally followed by the SW & JWs, but not necessarily).



Men in a Tavern, Engraving by William Hogarth, 1731

Festive Board Etiquette

Mobile Phones

Phones should be:

- switched off, or
- silent,
- or used discreetly, only if necessary (i.e. NEVER!).
- No photos should be taken without permission

Dress

The dress code remains formal throughout the evening. Jackets & ties normally stay on.

Conversation

Conversation & enjoyment are encouraged, but:

- stop immediately when the WM gavels,
- avoid speaking during toasts or speeches,
- be respectful to speakers…NO heckling

Alcohol

Historically, lodges often fined brethren for drunken behaviour or bad conduct at table…be watchful!

Giving a Speech or Reply

If asked to reply to a toast:

- keep it short,
- speak clearly,
- & thank the proposer



Understanding Toasts

At most Festive Boards, a series of formal toasts are given during the evening. These are traditional expressions of respect, loyalty & goodwill. The rigid protocols of the toasts have evolved to maintain order & respect, ensuring that the harmony in the Lodge is not lost in the relaxed atmosphere of the dining room.

The toasts & speeches are coordinated by the DC, who stands behind the WM to guide him. Before each toast the WM gavels, & at the end of each toast all who are standing will sit.

Prior to the formal toasts there is usually a return of grace, which can either be said or sung. After the return of grace, and before the formal toasts commence, all must sit.

Note that all of the formal toasts are FIRED; if a toast calls for a response, however, the response is NOT fired.

What Is “Masonic Fire”?



The “Masonic Fire” is a traditional form of salute given after certain toasts.

It developed in the 1700s from military-style gun salutes & evolved into a ceremonial Masonic custom. A fire should be done **in time & in unison**...

The fire usually involves:

- defined hand movements,
- specific clapping patterns,
- & a coordinated response led by the WM.

Different provinces & lodges may perform the fire slightly differently.

The important thing to remember is:

- follow the WM,
- don’t worry if you get it wrong,
- & everyone was new once!

All the toasts are fired. Note that WM always leads the masonic fire but may occasionally invite another brother to do so.

Note that each toast is preceded by a single knock of the WM, SW & JW's gavels. Once the the JW has gaveled, the principal officers stand. ***Note that this occurs up to & including the toast to the Province, after which toast the Wardens remain seated***.



Abundance by Peter Paul Rubens, c. 1630. Painting depicts a cornucopia, the ancient Greek symbol of abundance. The fruits that spill forth symbolize the goodness of nature for mankind.



Steward: A cornucopia between the legs of a compass extended

The Hertfordshire Toast List

1. The Loyal Toast

"The King, the Craft & Royal Arch Masonry"

This is the traditional opening toast of the evening.

It expresses:

- loyalty to the Crown,
- loyalty to Freemasonry,
- & recognition of Royal Arch Masonry.

This toast is normally given by the Worshipful Master & does not require a reply.

2. The Grand Master & Grand Officers

This toast recognizes the leadership of Freemasonry under the United Grand Lodge of England.

The Grand Master is: His Royal Highness The Duke of Kent

The toast also recognizes:

- the Pro Grand Master,
- Deputy Grand Master,
- Assistant Grand Masters,
- & Grand Officers present & past.

Grand Officers will remain seated, while ALL brethren stand to toast them.

3. The Provincial Grand Master

The toast to the head of Freemasonry within Hertfordshire,

When the Provincial Grand Master is present (like this evening!), this becomes one of the principal toasts of the evening & will normally receive a reply from the PGM.

If in attendance, the PGM remains seated for the toast. ALL brethren stand to toast him.

4. The Deputy & Assistant Provincial Grand Masters

This toast recognizes the senior Provincial team who assist in running the Province & supporting Lodges throughout Hertfordshire. Note that the Toast to the Deputy and Assistant PGMs is not done if the PGM is present; in which case, there is a single Toast to the PGM and "the Provincial Grand Lodge of Hertfordshire".

Again, this toast may receive a formal response if the Deputy and Assistant PGMs are present.

5. The Worshipful Master

A toast to the Master of the Lodge in recognition of his leadership during the meeting & Festive Board.

This is usually proposed by the Immediate Past Master, who will call for a response.

6. The Initiate or Initiates

One of the most important & enjoyable toasts of the evening.

This formally welcomes newly initiated Brethren into Freemasonry & into the lodge itself.

For many new masons, this is the first time they have been publicly welcomed as a brother at the Festive Board. The initiate will often be required to reply to the toast. His proposer should assist him in composing an appropriate & short reply to the WM & brethren, ideally starting with the words:

"*WM, Grand Officers, brethren all. Thank you for the way that you proposed that toast & thank you brethren for the way that you received it*. (*Unaccustomed as I am (…ugh!)*)"

7. The Visiting Brethren

"*Visiting is the lifeblood of Freemasonry*" is a fairly common remark heard in the toast to the visitors. Hence this toast welcomes visiting brethren from other lodges & thanks them for attending.

The most likely first experience a young Freemason will have in taking part in the Festive Board is being asked to Toast the Visitors (if a member of that lodge) or respond On Behalf of the Visitors (if visiting a lodge).

A visitor will be asked to reply on behalf of all visitors present. Often the visitor's host will be asked/volunteered by the DC or WM in the week leading up to the meeting to enquire as to whether his guest would be happy to reply on behalf of the visitors.

- Toast to the visitors: Keep the toast about them. Thank the visitors for attending & hope they enjoyed the evening & will visit again. Then call a fire & invite a nominated visitor to respond, quoting his name, lodge name & number.
- Response on behalf of the visitors: Thank the Lodge for its hospitality, mention any highlights of the evening, and conclude on behalf of all the visitors present. The reply on behalf of the visitors traditionally also starts with the same words:

  "*WM, Grand Officers, brethren all. Thank you for the way that you proposed that toast & thank you brethren for the way that you received it*."

Note that it is good form to give the visitor plenty of notice, & not to ask him at the bar to respond just before the festive board!

8. Absent Brethren (the Nine O'Clock Toast)

A toast of quiet reflection for all brethren unable to attend the meeting.

This may include:

- Brethren who are ill…
- …struggling…
- …or absent for other reasons (e.g. business, holidays, etc., but *excluding* being dead!)

Lodges observe this toast differently, but always respectfully.

Note that often the toast isn't at 9 o'clock. However, "*Somewhere, brethren, the hands are on the square*"…

9. The Tyler's Toast

The very first recorded instance of a Tyler's Toast in Freemasonry is believed to be from Laurence Dermott's "Ahiman Rezon", The Book of Constitutions of This Grand Lodge, published in 1756, which became the constitutional foundation of Antients Freemasonry.

Traditionally the final toast of the evening. It is introduced by a double knock of the WM's gavel. The toast is given by the Tyler who will stand & move from his place to stand behind the WM to give his toast.

The Tyler's Toast is fired, with the fire led by the Tyler. Note that it is the only fire NOT formally led by the WM.

The toast is focused on:

- friendship,
- absent Brethren,
- ...& a safe return home for all masons.

Many brethren consider this one of the most memorable traditions of the Festive Board.



Absent Brethren: Freemasons held as prisoners of war in Soltau POW Camp, Germany, 1916 - 1917.

Photograph from collection of Sgt Rowland Hill (Nigeria Regiment), who was captured on 15th January 1916 near Madeira aboard the SS Appam & held at Soltau from 1916 until the end of WWI.

Identified Brethren: Daniel Cook (Lodge Perseverance No. 1018), Pte W.R. Simonds, 10th Canadians (Lodge Mizpah No. 35, Medicine Hat, Alberta), L/Cpl Hugh A.R. MacLennan, 1st Cameron Highlanders (Lodge Langside No. 955, Glasgow), Russell Taylor (Lodge St John No. 967, Coatbridge) & George C. Hughes (Lodge Lebong No. 3323, Bengal).

Common Questions from New Masons

“What if I get something wrong?”

Don’t worry. Every mason in the room this evening was once new & learning exactly the same traditions.

The important thing is simply to:

- observe,
- follow the lead of others,
- & enjoy the evening!

“When should I stand?”

Generally:

- stand when invited to by the DC or WM,
- stand when responding to a toast,
- stand during formal toasts when requested.

If unsure, simply follow the brethren around you.

“Do I need to know the Toasts?”

No - most newer brethren simply observe during their early meetings & follow their neighbours at the table.

“Can I visit other Lodges?”

Absolutely. Visiting other Lodges is one of the best ways to:

- make friends,
- experience different traditions,
- and enjoy the wider Province.

The FHLBC actively encourages Light Blues to visit widely throughout Hertfordshire.

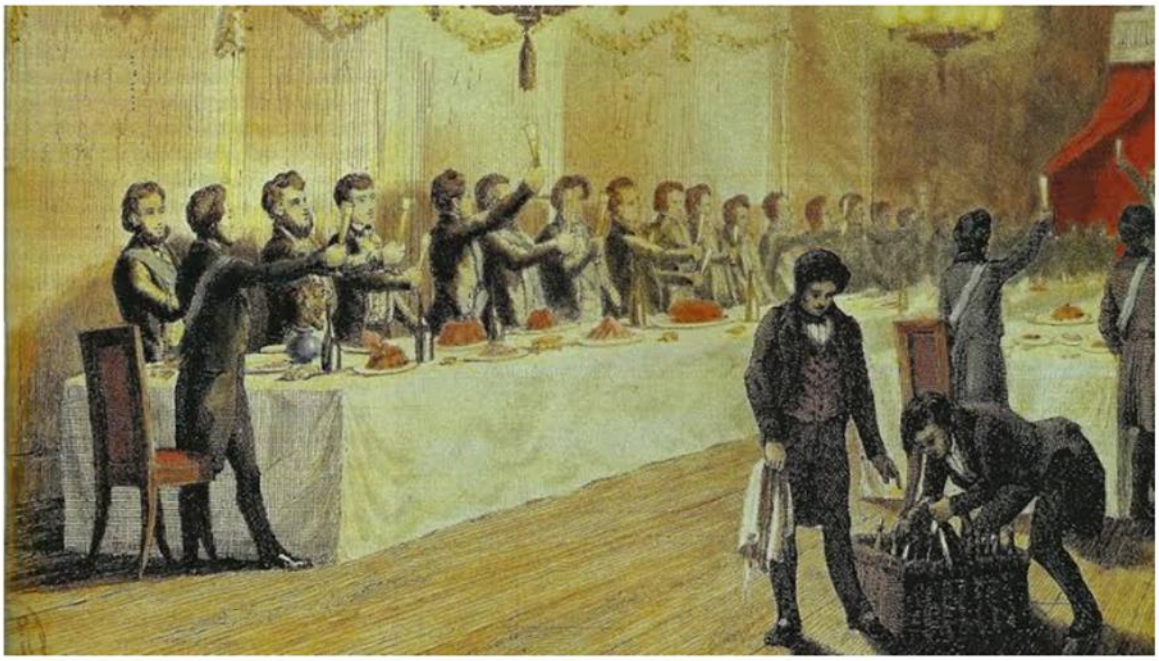
Final Thoughts

Freemasonry is not only experienced in ritual & ceremony. It is also experienced:

- in conversation,
- in friendship,
- in laughter,
- ....all of which all happen around the Festive Board table.

For many brethren, some of their happiest memories in Freemasonry are made at the festive board, & the brother to your left or right will become your lifelong friend.

Relax, observe, join in, & enjoy!



The Tyler's Toast *by Rudyard Kipling*

'Are your glasses all charged in the West & the South?' the Worshipful Master cried!

'All charged in the West'

'All charged in the South'

Came the Wardens' prompt reply.

Then to our final toast tonight, our glasses freely drain,

Happy to meet, sorry to part, happy to meet again. *(Response - ALL)*

The mason's social brotherhood around the festive board,

Reveals a truth more precious far, than any miser's hoard.

We freely share the bounteous gifts, that generous hearts contain,

Happy to meet, sorry to part, happy to meet again.

We meet as masons free & true, & when our work is done,

The merry song & social glass is not unduly won.

And only at our farewell pledge is pleasure mixed with pain,

Happy to meet, sorry to part, happy to meet again.

Amidst our mirth we drink to all poor masons o'er the Earth,

On every shore our flag of love is gloriously unfurled.

We prize each Brother, fair or dark, who bears no moral stain,

Happy to meet, sorry to part, happy to meet again.

We Masons prize that noble truth, the Scottish peasant told,

That rank is but a guinea stamp: The man himself the gold.

We meet the rich & poor alike, the equal rights maintain,

Happy to meet, sorry to part, happy to meet again.

Dear brethren of the mystic tie, the night is waning fast,

Our work is done, our feast is o'er, this toast must be the last.

Good night to all, once more good night,

again that farewell strain,

Happy to meet, sorry to part, happy to meet again!

The Tyler's Toast, *Traditional*

To all poor & distressed Freemasons,

Wherever they may be,

On the land, on the sea, or in the air.

Wishing them a speedy relief from all their sufferings,

And a safe return to their native land,

Should they so desire.

(Response - ALL)

To all poor & distressed Freemasons!

